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Resetting to a clean state

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Resetting to a Clean State

Most people arriving in this course have already fiddled with some kind of [agentic](#) setup: a few [MCP](#) servers, some settings, a pile of [skills](#), a plugin or two. Which means the setup you are bringing is almost certainly **over-configured** — and every piece of it ships on every [turn](#), whether or not this week's work has anything to do with it.

Start from a small, known state instead. Delete it — most of it you do not need — or, if you are precious about it, back it up first. Both labs assume you know what is in your setup, and you cannot know that until you have taken it apart.

Let the agent do it

Your agent is the expert on its own configuration. Give it the prompt below; it inventories everything, moves it to a dated backup directory, and writes the restore instructions.

```
You are the expert on your own configuration. Reset me to a clean slate (the config a fresh install

**1. Inventory.** Consult your own documentation for where your configuration lives, then find every
**2. Back it up.** Create `~/agent-config-backup-<today's date>` and MOVE each item there, mirrori
**3. Write the restore instructions.** Add `RESTORE.md` at the root of the backup listing every bac
**4. Verify.** Re-run the inventory from step 1. Report what remains and confirm each remaining ite

Keep me signed in – leave auth, credential, and session files exactly where they are. Keep this pro

Finish with a table of what was moved and the one-line command I can give you later to restore it.
```

Nothing here is agent-specific: the prompt tells the agent to consult its own documentation, so it works on whichever [harness](#) you use.

What it finds

In Claude Code the inventory typically comes back looking like this:

Path	What it does
<code>~/.claude/settings.json</code>	Main settings: tool denies, <code>defaultMode</code> , <code>effortLevel</code> , <code>tui</code> , auto-memory
<code>~/.claude/settings.local.json</code>	WebFetch allow rules, WebSearch
<code>~/.claude/CLAUDE.md</code>	Global memory file
<code>~/.claude/skills/</code>	User skills (often symlinks)
<code>~/.claude/hooks/</code>	Executable hook scripts
<code>~/.claude/plugins/</code>	Installed plugins
<code>~/.claude.json</code>	MCP servers, per-project permissions and trust, plus auth and identity

Plus the locations that turned out to be empty — `~/.claude/agents/`, `commands/`, `output-styles/`, `rules/`. Those matter too: knowing a directory is empty is knowing where a thing would go if you added one, which is exactly what Lab 2 asks you to do.

Test the restore before you trust it

A backup you have never restored is a hope, not a backup. [Clear](#) your [session](#) and paste the one-liner the agent gave you back:

```
Restore my config from ~/agent-config-backup-<date>/RESTORE.md
```

It reads `RESTORE.md` and puts everything back. Then reset again and get on with the course.

Why bother

Two reasons, and the second is the one that counts.

The obvious one: the course material stops interacting with configuration nobody in the room can see, so when your agent does something strange this week it is because of something you wrote this week.

The real one: at the end of the course you choose what goes back. Most people restore a fraction of what they backed up, because a config you have lived without for two weeks and not missed was never earning its place in the [context window](#). Deleting is hard; restoring selectively from a backup you already trust is easy. That is the whole trick.

Credits

aihero.dev (Matt Pocock).

Modifié le: jeudi 27 août 2026, 21:17